Baptized into Christ

Jesus commanded baptism for his disciples; Presbyterian and Reformed churches receive it as the sign and seal of God's covenant of grace, given to believers and their children.

Main passage	Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:3-4 (KJV)
Topic	Baptism
Version	Presbyterian and Reformed (contested point: Baptism)
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Commanded by Christ for his disciples	7 min
Teaching point 2: Baptized into Christ's death and resurrection	7 min
Teaching point 3: Baptism: the sign and seal of God's covenant	9 min
Where Christians differ (hidden by default; optional)	optional
Discussion questions	6 min
Application	2 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask the class, if they are comfortable sharing: "Do you remember your baptism, or have you been told about it? What do you remember, or what were you told?" Some will remember a river or a baptistry; others were baptized as babies and have only photographs. Some may not have been baptized at all. Explain that baptism is something Jesus commanded, and today we look at what it means.

Teacher note: Be gentle with anyone who has not been baptized or whose experience differs from the class's. The goal is understanding, not embarrassment.

Scripture (3 min)

Matthew 28:18-20

18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.

19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Romans 6:3-4

3 Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? 4 Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life.

Read both passages aloud: first Jesus' command (Matthew 28:18-20), then Paul's explanation of what baptism means (Romans 6:3-4).

Background (5 min)

Matthew 28:18-20, often called the Great Commission, are Jesus' last words in Matthew's Gospel. With all authority in heaven and earth, he sends his followers to make disciples of all nations, "baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost," and teaching them to obey all he commanded.

In Romans 6 Paul answers a question: if we are saved by grace, should we keep on sinning? His answer points to baptism. Those baptized into Christ were baptized into his death, and they are to walk in "newness of life." Christians in every tradition treasure these verses, even where they understand baptism's details differently.

Teaching point 1: Commanded by Christ for his disciples (7 min)

Baptism was not invented by the church. Jesus himself commanded it, as part of making disciples of all nations, in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Christians of every tradition baptize because Jesus told us to, and they use these words.

Supporting verses

Matthew 28:18-20: And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Acts 2:41: Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls.

Acts 8:12: But when they believed Philip preaching the things concerning the kingdom of God, and the name of Jesus Christ, they were baptized, both men and women.

> *"Baptism consists in applying water to a person "in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Ghost," as Christ has commanded."*
>
> — Joseph Stump, An Explanation of Luther's Small Catechism, "What Baptism is"

Handout blanks (answers)

Baptize them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy **Ghost (Spirit)**.

Christians baptize because **Jesus** commanded it.

Teaching point 2: Baptized into Christ's death and resurrection (7 min)

Paul says that "so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death" (Romans 6:3). Baptism is about union with Christ: belonging to him, sharing in what his death and resurrection accomplished, and being marked as his.

Supporting verses

Romans 6:3-4: Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life.

Galatians 3:27: For as many of you as have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ.

Colossians 2:12: Buried with him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised him from the dead.

> *"sealed with the seal of heaven, and as it were formally entered and articled, to all the benefits and all the obligations of Christian discipleship"*
>
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Romans 6:3

> *"To be baptized into Christ, is to receive the doctrine of Christ crucified"*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Romans 6:3

Handout blanks (answers)

So many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his **death**.

Baptism speaks of our **union** with Christ.

Teaching point 3: Baptism: the sign and seal of God's covenant (9 min)

Presbyterian and Reformed churches teach that baptism is a sacrament, a sign and seal of God's covenant of grace. In the Old Testament, God gave circumcision as the covenant sign to Abraham and his children (Genesis 17:7-12). In the New Testament, baptism takes its place (Colossians 2:11-12), and the promise is still "unto you, and to your children" (Acts 2:39). So believers are baptized, and so are their children; whole households were baptized when parents believed (Acts 16:15, 33). Sprinkling or pouring is usual. Baptism

does not automatically make anyone a Christian: the grace it signifies is received by faith, and the baptized child is raised to trust Christ personally.

Supporting verses

Genesis 17:7: And I will establish my covenant between me and thee and thy seed after thee in their generations for an everlasting covenant, to be a God unto thee, and to thy seed after thee.

Colossians 2:11-12: In whom also ye are circumcised with the circumcision made without hands, in putting off the body of the sins of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ: Buried with him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised him from the dead.

Acts 2:39: For the promise is unto you, and to your children, and to all that are afar off, even as many as the Lord our God shall call.

Acts 16:14-15: And a certain woman named Lydia, a seller of purple, of the city of Thyatira, which worshipped God, heard us: whose heart the Lord opened, that she attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul. And when she was baptized, and her household, she besought us, saying, If ye have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come into my house, and abide there. And she constrained us.

1 Corinthians 7:14: For the unbelieving husband is sanctified by the wife, and the unbelieving wife is sanctified by the husband: else were your children unclean; but now are they holy.

> *"And so, too, the question respecting infant baptism is not so much whether a parent OUGHT to devote his children to God in this ordinance, as whether he MAY do it."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Mark 10:16

> *"Infant baptism tacitly superseded infant circumcision"*
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 1 Corinthians 7:14

Handout blanks (answers)

Baptism is a sign and **seal** of God's covenant.

The promise is unto you, and to your **children**.

Teacher note: Albert Barnes, the Presbyterian commentator, calls presenting children for baptism "an inestimable privilege." Interestingly, he also cautions (on Acts 2:39) that that verse should not be used on its own as proof of infant baptism; the Reformed case rests on the whole covenant pattern of Scripture.

Where Christians differ

In this tradition's version, this section is hidden from the class materials unless the user turns it on. It is included here so the teacher knows the other views.

Christians agree that Jesus commanded baptism, that it is done with water in the name of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit, that it is linked with repentance, faith, forgiveness and union with Christ, and that true baptism is not repeated. They differ on three questions: who should be baptized (believers only, or also the

children of believers), how (immersion, or also pouring and sprinkling), and what baptism does (a means through which God gives grace, a sign and seal of his covenant, or an act of obedience that testifies to grace already received). Here are the main views of the five traditions, each described as its own teachers describe it. Sincere, Bible-believing Christians hold each of them.

Baptist

Baptists teach "believer's baptism": baptism is for those who have personally repented and put their faith in Christ, and it is done by immersing the whole body in water, picturing death, burial and resurrection with Christ. Baptism is an ordinance of obedience and a public confession of faith; it does not itself save or convey grace, but follows salvation. Because infants cannot yet believe, they are not baptized; many Baptist churches hold a service of dedication instead, and a person baptized as an infant is baptized as a believer.

Key texts: Matthew 28:19-20; Acts 2:41; Acts 8:36-38; Romans 6:3-4; Colossians 2:12

Methodist and Wesleyan

Methodists and Wesleyans treat baptism as a sacrament: an outward sign of an inward grace and a means by which God works. It marks entry into the church and God's covenant, and it is given both to adults who come to faith and to the infants of Christian families. Pouring or sprinkling is usual, though immersion is also accepted. John Wesley linked baptism with the new birth, but taught that every baptized person must still personally turn to Christ and be born of the Spirit; baptized children are later confirmed in their own profession of faith.

Key texts: Acts 2:38-39; Mark 10:13-16; Colossians 2:11-12; Titus 3:5

Presbyterian and Reformed

Presbyterian and Reformed churches teach that baptism is a sacrament, a sign and seal of God's covenant of grace, which in the New Testament takes the place of circumcision. It is given to those who profess faith and also to the children of believing parents, because God's covenant promise is "unto you, and to your children" (Acts 2:39). Sprinkling or pouring is usual and immersion is valid. The grace signified is not tied to the moment of baptism and is received by faith; baptism does not automatically regenerate, and it is administered only once.

Key texts: Genesis 17:7-12; Colossians 2:11-12; Acts 2:38-39; Acts 16:14-15, 31-33; 1 Corinthians 7:14

Lutheran

Lutherans teach that baptism is a means of grace: not simply water, but water joined to God's command and promise. Through it God gives forgiveness of sins, rescue from death and the devil, and eternal salvation to all who believe. Faith receives the gift, and God works faith even in infants through his Word, so children are baptized. The Augsburg Confession calls baptism necessary to salvation (while Lutherans do not teach that the unbaptized who believe are lost). Pouring is the usual mode. The baptized person returns daily to baptism by repentance and faith.

Key texts: Mark 16:16; Matthew 28:19; Titus 3:5; Acts 2:38-39; 1 Peter 3:21

Pentecostal and Charismatic

Most Pentecostal churches (for example the Assemblies of God and the Foursquare Church) practise believer's baptism by immersion, much as Baptists do: an act of obedience and public testimony by those who have been born again, not a means of salvation. Infants are dedicated, not baptized. Pentecostals give special emphasis to a second, distinct "baptism in the Holy Spirit" (see the lesson on spiritual gifts). A minority ("Oneness" Pentecostals) baptize in the name of Jesus only; most Pentecostals use the threefold name of Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

Key texts: Matthew 28:19; Mark 16:16; Acts 2:38; Acts 8:36-38; Romans 6:4

Teacher note: Encourage the class to describe other traditions' views as their own members would. Many Christians from these traditions worship and serve together and recognise one another as brothers and sisters in Christ.

Discussion questions (6 min)

1. What do all Christians agree about baptism, according to today's passages?

Jesus commanded it; it is done in the name of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit; it is linked with discipleship, faith and union with Christ; it calls us to new life.

2. Why do Reformed churches connect baptism with circumcision?

Both are signs of God's one covenant of grace; circumcision was given to believers' children, and Colossians 2:11-12 links the two, so baptism is also given to believers' children.

3. What does Romans 6 say baptism should mean for the way we live this week?

We have died to sin with Christ and been raised to walk in newness of life; we live as people who belong to him.

4. How can we hold our own convictions about baptism while showing love to Christians who practise it differently?

By being clear about what Scripture teaches as we understand it, listening carefully, describing others fairly, and remembering that we share one Lord and one faith.

Application (2 min)

If you were baptized as a child, thank God this week for his covenant faithfulness to you and your family, and make sure your own faith rests on Christ. If you have children or grandchildren, pray for them by name as children of the covenant.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Faithful God, you keep covenant with your people and their children. Thank you for the sign and seal of baptism. Help us trust in Christ, the one baptism points to, and raise our children to know and love you. Amen.

Sources quoted

Joseph Stump, An Explanation of Luther's Small Catechism, “What Baptism is”

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Romans 6:3

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Romans 6:3

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Mark 10:16

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 1 Corinthians 7:14

Every quotation was checked word for word against the library text it cites. All sources are in the public domain.